was prepared for lunch, including some of my favourites. As I sat there, my face as long as a fiddle, while everyone enjoyed drinks, Maa offered starters to the guests.

‘Won’t Gunjan eat her favourite kebabs?’ one of the officers asked Maa when she passed by me without offering me any.

‘She’s on a weight-loss regime,’ Papaji answered. ‘She got recommended and now she has to lose weight to clear her medical tests.’

‘Congratulations’ came in unison, and I replied with a forced but humble smile. Mouth-watering snacks kept on coming while I sat there, almost depressed at not being able to eat any of it. I could have made it through if I was allowed to go to my room but Maa thought it would be disrespectful to do so. Finally, when lunch was laid out on the table and everyone filled their plates, when the smell of hot butter chicken and malai kofta reached my nostrils, I broke down. Without saying a word, I got up and sped into my room, leaving behind an embarrassed Papaji. I just could not take it any more. When the guests left, Papaji came to my room.

‘Is this your best?’ he asked calmly. I looked the other way.

‘You said you’ll try your best,’ he said.

‘I can’t do it,’ I said, without looking at him, ‘when everybody else enjoys eating my favourite food in front of me.’

‘But it’s just for a few weeks,’ Papaji said.

‘You don’t understand, Papaji, I’ve never been on diet for even half a day in my life,’ I retorted. ‘I hate it.’

‘Then how do we solve this problem?’ he asked.

‘I don’t know,’ I replied in frustration.

‘I . . . I think I know,’ he said. ‘We’ve done it once, we’ll do it again.’

* * *

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‘I don’t want to eat,’ I said as we all seated ourselves at the dinner table.

‘Why? What happened?’ Maa asked as she passed the pickle to Dada.